recognized as Ratan's seminal contribution to the Tata Group. This led some scholars and commentators to draw a comparison between JRD and Ratan as business leaders.

'For all the praises lavished on JRD, the fact is that he created an industrial group seriously unready to face a new era of economic reform, globalization and knowledge-intensity,' wrote journalist and columnist Swaminathan Aiyar. In comparison, he added, Ratan had 'articulated a vision of a new-look Tata empire based on high technology, a concept whose significance few comprehended during the licence-permit raj … [and] reshaped his group to cater to the 21st century'.

Implementing Recommendations

Ratan is not generally perceived to be a man in a hurry. But he is. Yet, he is unlike most other achievers and as is his wont, rarely speaks about his accomplishments. This led to both positive and negative outcomes during his chairmanship. It was an advantage as he let his work speak for itself, leading to a more convincing and enduring assessment of his capabilities. The downside was that he often received less publicity for what he was doing than he could have, making him vulnerable to the uninformed public who believed his detractors' claims that he was a non-performer.

After sending his letter to JRD in 1978, Ratan went about implementing the contours of his 1983 Strategic Plan. He did not wait for the support of the two holding companies—TIL and Tata Sons—or that of the stalwarts of the group. They were, if anything, opposed to his plan.

But almost all the new projects the group started during the decade and after, had their genesis in his Strategic Plan. By the time JRD was ready to step down in 1991, these changes could be seen across the group. It included forays into high-tech areas, the modernization of TISCO, new fertilizer projects, acquisitions, the expansion of TELCO, the initiation of negotiations for technological collaboration in the field of biotechnology, and leasing activities.

Ratan's emphasis was on high-tech industries. JRD also subscribed to this philosophy. JRD had said, 'It would be ideal for the Tatas to get the opportunities to enter high-technology, high-risk industries. In fact, it is almost a duty since only large groups can afford to take risks, and there are a number of areas India should get into.'